

complete with its by-products, the rise of the peeping paparazzi, tabloid hot type and media-savvy loonies readying to take over the asylum. In the new democracy of celebrity, everyone was equal, the star who sought anonymity and the starlet who craved attention. The media became at once the pursuer and the pursued. For every Abhishek and Aishwarya protecting their privacy, there was a Jahnvi waiting to woo with her sordid tale of intimacy. For every Aamir Khan seeking the audience's attention for his directorial debut, there was a Rakhi Sawant agitating, complete with tears and toyboy, about unfair voting. As C. Wright Mills said so famously, "In the world of the celebrity, the hierarchy of publicity has replaced the hierarchy of descent and even of great wealth."

But 2007 was supposed to be a new world, where the old made place for fresh flesh, where a new generation of stars would walk all over a group of 40-year-olds, some tarnished by scandal, others just weathered by age. It didn't quite happen. God makes stars, Samuel Goldwyn had said, it's up to producers to find them. Find them they did. And they also put them through the grinder, shaping their eyebrows, making them lose their puppy fat, force-feeding the classics,

teaching them dance moves, doing everything to eclipse a generation of stars that has been with us since before satellite television and the cell phone, the two greatest gifts of liberalised India.

Yet it was the fabulous 40s who reigned—and in the south, it was a fantabulous 58-year-old, shaving his head, lightening his skin, serenading a siren and ruling over an ever widening swathe. In Bollywood, one man developed a six-pack, another went to jail—which only seemed to enhance his bad boy appeal—another directed a little movie with a big heart, and yet another, not a Khan but a Kumar, discovered his own, and the audience's funny bone. The youngsters, most of whom were dynasty's offsprings (one who was not was the child of a sporting icon), did not quite conquer, despite an impassioned Sanjay Leela Bhansali's plea to embrace the new.

It was a clash of generations, but it was also a clash of genres. The traditional Bollywood drama, oozing with stars in splendid costumes and splendiferous destinations (Paris! New York! Geneva!), found itself wanting when faced with a new kind of film, the unheralded but smartly targeted little movie. This was a genre that thrived on the small idea. It could be a twisted little urban comedy like *Bheja Fry*; a small-town noir film that challenged notions of stardom like *Manorama*:

Six Feet Under; a searing expose of what happened in Gujarat told through the trauma of one family in *Parzania*; even a seemingly rainbow coalition of the girls of India in *Chak de! India*. The big budget

movies paled in comparison, whether it was the miserable-in-Manhattan *Ta Ra*



CLASHES

P.R. DASMUNSHI Vs THE MEDIA

The I&B Minister tried to muzzle the media by painting everyone with the sting brush.



RAKHI SAWANT Vs KASHMIRA SHAH

They carried the *Bigg Boss* animosity to the *Nach Baliye 3* set.

BACHCHAN Vs SHAH RUKH

They swore devotion but studiously avoided each other.

VIDHU VINOD CHOPRA Vs BHAWNA TALWA

He thought *Eklavya* was worthy of being India's official Oscar entry. She thought *Dharm* was. Neither is likely to win.



Photo Montage
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